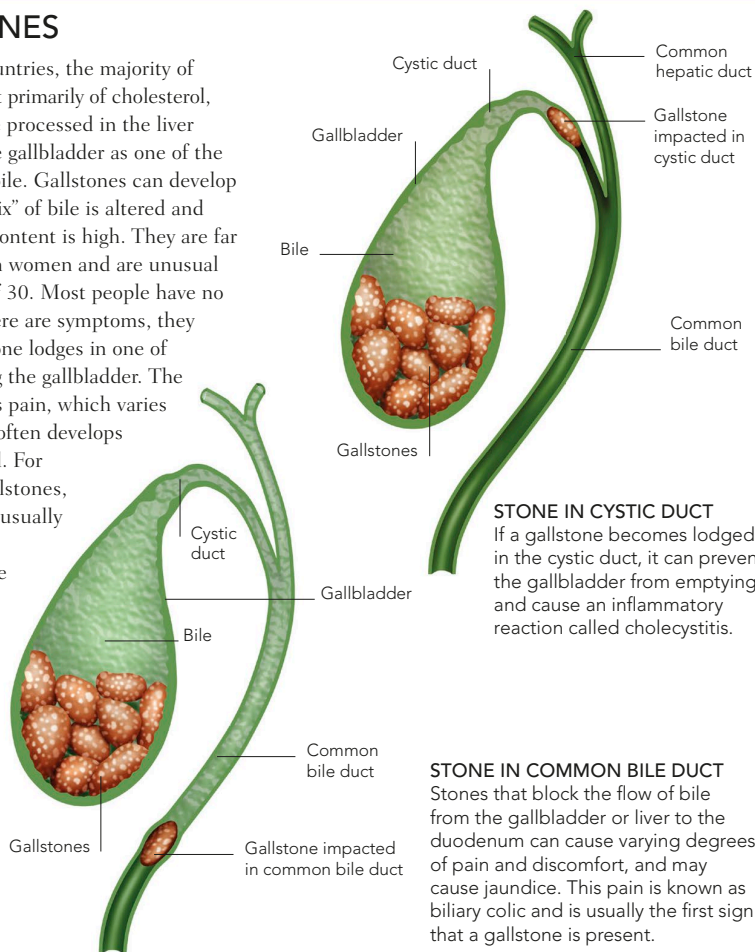


GALLSTONES

In developed countries, the majority of gallstones consist primarily of cholesterol, a fatty substance processed in the liver and stored in the gallbladder as one of the constituents of bile. Gallstones can develop if the normal “mix” of bile is altered and the cholesterol content is high. They are far more common in women and are unusual before the age of 30. Most people have no symptoms. If there are symptoms, they begin when a stone lodges in one of the ducts leaving the gallbladder. The main symptom is pain, which varies in intensity and often develops after a fatty meal. For symptomatic gallstones, the treatment is usually cholecystectomy (often by keyhole surgery) to remove the gallbladder.



PANCREATITIS

Pancreatitis is a serious inflammation of the pancreas, and can be either acute or chronic. In both types, the inflammation is triggered by the enzymes that the pancreas itself normally manufactures to aid the digestion of food when it enters the duodenum. In pancreatitis, these enzymes become activated while they are still inside the pancreas, and begin to digest the tissue.

There are many causes of acute pancreatitis, the most common of which are gallstones (see above), excessive intake of alcohol, some drugs, and certain infections, such as mumps. Chronic pancreatitis is usually associated with long-term alcoholism. In both types, the main feature is pain. In acute pancreatitis, this is particularly severe and may be accompanied by nausea and vomiting.